

THE CROWN OF THORNS

Pakistan's new prime minister has to tread carefully through a minefield of issues that could cause his stewardship to implode

■ By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi

More than a month after the elections, as Makhdoom Syed Yusuf Raza Gilani was sworn-in as Pakistan's 25th prime minister on March 25, all the palace intrigues and intra-coalition power disputes that preceded his nomination seemed to have become a footnote in history. Gilani had been elected to his post by a whopping 264 of the 342 members of the National Assembly (NA) and was sworn-in by the same man—a visibly uncomfortable President Pervez Musharraf—whose military regime had arrested and jailed him for more than five years in an apparent attempt to make him abandon his allegiance to Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP). Makhdoom Amin Fahim, a disgruntled one-time front-runner from PPP for the post of prime minister was effectively sidelined—avoiding a threatened split within the party—and even the pro-Musharraf Muttahida Qaumi Movement (MQM) decided to support Gilani's nomination “unconditionally” by adding its 25 votes to the ruling coalition's burgeoning tally.

Earlier, on March 17, emotional scenes had been witnessed during the election of the new premier in the Assembly when Bilawal Bhutto Zardari, the young son of slain leader Benazir Bhutto and new chairman of PPP, who was sitting in the visitor's gallery, could not control his tears as his mother's name was invoked by party loyalists. Gilani himself set the dynamic

tone for the new parliament immediately after his election, freeing from house arrest the superior court judges who had been unceremoniously sacked by Musharraf on November 3, 2007. He also announced his intention to fulfil PPP's pledge to have Benazir's assassination investigated by the UN, a demand that Musharraf had ignored. The loud desk thumping and popular acclaim that followed Gilani's speech was followed a few hours later by the spectacle of hundreds of lawyers and activists thronging the residence of the deposed chief justice Iftikhar Chaudhry as rolls of barbed wire were removed from in front of his house. The former chief justice appeared on the balcony of his house to wave to a tumultuous crowd celebrating what seems to be a new spring for democracy. The next day's *Dawn* carried a banner headline that read simply “A Momentous Day”.

If only all that awaits Gilani in the future were so simple and so easily handled. In fact, Pakistan's new premier must tread a minefield of issues that could easily cause his stewardship to implode. Of course, the issue in the public eye at the moment is that of the judiciary. The Murree Declaration signed by the main coalition partners, PPP and the Pakistan Muslim League (Nawaz), calls for the sacked judges to be restored to their positions within 30 days. The lawyers have already served notice of the beginning of the countdown and even threatened street protests if the issue is not settled within the promised timeframe.



But aside from the legal complexities of how this is to be achieved, Gilani must also contend with the political fallout of such a restoration, since it would directly affect President Musharraf's position. There may be no love lost between Musharraf and PPP but the party is also under tremendous pressure from Washington to work with the Americans' trusted ally. The visit of Deputy US Secretary of State John Negroponte and Assistant Secretary of State Richard Boucher to Islamabad a few hours after Gilani's swearing in is widely perceived—and resented—as an attempt to drive home the point. According to PPP's Shah Mahmood Qureshi, tipped to be the country's next foreign minister, the issue of the presidency must be handled with cau-

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